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Tom Malone

Multi-instrumentalist Tom "Bones" Malone has found success as a first call studio musician, arranger, music director, and as a member of numerous iconic ensembles. His versatility has enabled him to be involved in virtually every aspect of the music business.

Tom was interviewed via Zoom on May 3, 2023 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive and what a gas to have Tom "Bones" Malone with me today. Thank you, sir.

TM: My pleasure to be here.

MR: So I thought what we would do is list every gig you've ever played and every person you've ever played with and then six hours later I'll ask my first question.

TM: Well I played with everybody except Frank Sinatra. And I got a call to play with him in Atlantic City from Joe Malin, his string contractor/concertmaster, and I already had another job so I had to turn down Frank Sinatra. Can you believe that?

MR: Wow.

TM: So my career went right downhill right there, that day.

MR: That says something about your professionalism.

TM: Well you know you have to do the right thing. Word gets around quickly in the business.

MR: That sort of leads me to this question I thought I would ask. I don't know if you have an ego or not, but if you do I wonder if you could set it aside for a moment and I'm wondering why your calendar for decades has been so full and you've been so successful in the business? What is it about you that people keep calling?

TM: Well uh, I try to do the right thing. I don't have a music degree, I have a degree in psychology. I'm more or less a self-taught musician. But I play 16 instruments professionally. Right now my current project is I'm doing a big band album at my house by myself. A typical song is — I'm not sure if I sent you any of this stuff — but a typical song is two alto saxes, two tenor saxes, baritone sax, four trumpets, three trombones, bass trombone, bass, piano, drums so —

MR: What do you start with?

TM: Started out on the violin when I was five.

MR: But I mean with this recording you're working on, if you're doing a lot of these parts yourself — is that what you mean? You're playing them yourself?

TM: I do all the parts myself. I lay down the drums and then the bass and then the piano, and

Neumann U87 microphone, which is the best microphone ever built. If you ever see a video of some famous singer, they will, you will notice that they have a Neumann U87 microphone hanging down from the microphone hanger.

MR: I can just picture when you get into the ensemble stuff and like — oh that second alto player man, he's not in tune in that section. Oops — that's me.

TM: Well I played one instrument or another with somebody in my career. You know I was tenor sax soloist with Frank Zappa. I was a trumpet player with Blood, Sweat & Tears with Lew Soloff, 1973. And I played jazz tuba, I played on Howard Johnson's last five tuba recordings. On and on and on.

MR: I have some of those Howard Johnson records. They are a delight.

TM: Oh Howard Johnson was a dear friend of mine from early on in New York. My career started in New York. I called Bob Burgess, "Can I crash on your floor" in New York. And I moved up from North Texas State, I moved to New York. And Bob went back on the road with Woody Herman pretty soon after I got there so I inherited this cheap apartment in New York City in Manhattan. A friend named Hannibal Marvin Peterson called me up one day and says, "Can I come up to New York and crash on your floor?" Hannibal Marvin Peterson was a black soul singer and a jazz trumpet player at North Texas State, a good friend of mine. So I said sure, come on up. So he's crashing on my floor and he immediately started working with Rahsaan Roland Kirk and Gil Evans. Rahsaan Roland Kirk was the guy who played three saxophones at the same time.

MR: Yes I saw him in Rochester.

TM: So one night Hannibal says, "I got two gigs tonight." He said, "The gig with Gil Evans doesn't pay anything. You want to sub for me with Gil Evans?" And I said sure. So I went down there and I met all these people, it changed the rest of my life. Howard Johnson, David Sanborn, Dave Bargeron, Lew Soloff, Bruce Ditmus, on and on and on. And so Howard Johnson and I hit it off because you know I play tuba and a lot of instruments, like he did. And he recommended me — I mean playing with Gil Evans that night I started playing with Gil Evans for the last 15 years of Gil's life. Toured all over the world with him. And Howard Johnson recommended me for the job at Saturday Night Live, it started in 1975. Dave Sanborn, I played on Dave Sanborn's first demo and played on his first three albums and on and on and on like that. I later was a trumpet player with Blood, Sweat & Tears, 1973 with Lew Soloff. Lew Soloff and I left the band at the end of '73 and went on to play with Gil Evans for the next 15 years.

MR: Guess who I was speaking with an hour ago on the phone? Fred Lipsius.

TM: Oh yes, oh my goodness, what a talented guy he is. Oh. He was the arranger for Blood, Sweat & Tears in the early days before I was in the band. And then my good friend of 56

years Lou Marini took Fred's place when he left the band, and went to be faculty at the Berklee School of Music.

MR: Right. If I went back to my original question, why — why did these people call you back, make referrals, say oh you want to do this now? I mean after that first Gil Evans gig is it as simple as that you were good and you were easy to get along with?

TM: Well as I mentioned before, I have a degree in psychology and I found that just be nice to everybody, regardless of whether you're a lawyer or an accountant or whatever your career is, be nice to people. It always pays off. I've worked with musicians that have difficult personalities and they tend to be traded off for somebody else. I mean if they can hire me or another guy that have similar professional skills who are they going to call? They're going to call the nice guy. The guy that gets along with everybody. So that's what I tell — when I lecture at colleges — basically what I do these days is headline jazz festivals — go to colleges, play with their band, lecture to the students.

MR: Yeah I know exactly what you're saying because like all musicians who book gigs, you know you get a gig and then sometimes you have to put a band together and you look at your list. The best player may not be the one you call first, because the best player may have some baggage going on and who needs that?

TM: I agree with you one hundred percent. Now I'm not saying that being a nice guy is going to get you gigs. You have to do the work. You have to be able to sight read, you have to be able to improvise, you have to be able to play in tune, you have to be able to play in time. You know there's all sorts of skills that we have to get. You have to get the skills. But when you have the skills and you treat people nicely doors will open.

MR: Do you recall the first time you put on headphones in the studio setting to record something and make a few dollars?

TM: Wow. I started recording in Dallas when I was in college at North Texas State. Somehow somebody got my name and I started going into Dallas twice a week to record on jingles with the top professionals there in town. It was — we would do eight or ten commercials during a one-hour session. That means you don't have time to practice the part. You have to be able to read it perfectly the first time or they'll throw you out and get somebody else for the next session.

MR: Where did those reading skills come from?

TM: I'm sorry?

MR: Where did your reading skills come from?

TM: Well I started off learning music at home but I really got to polish my skill at sight reading, polished at North Texas State. Every day in the One O'clock Band. I played lead trombone in the One O'clock Band at North Texas, and lead trumpet in the Three

there, and he says, I went in and auditioned and he says, "Okay get out of here." I said, "What do you mean?" I played the part perfectly. And he says, "I have 60 jazz saxophone majors here this semester. I only have 30 chairs, we only have six bands. He says, "And you're already playing in two bands and you're not even a music major so get out of here." I started off in college at University of Southern Mississippi as a music major. Now I had started transcribing music off of records when I was 13 at home. So I took a course called Music Theory 101. And I answered all the questions for the first couple of weeks. The teacher takes me out in the hall and he says, "You don't have to come to class anymore, you get an A."

MR: Well to me, on my end, it sounds like your whole life has been like that. I'm sure that's not quite true, but I'm going to go back to the Dallas recording things. When you were doing those things, bam-bam-bam one after the other, do you recall absorbing the idea of writing horn parts, listening — here's my horn part, how does it fit with the person next to me and sort of storing that for later when you did it?

TM: Oh absolutely. Well I started arranging when I was 13 so I understood the harmonies and stuff. I went to a small school, well a brief story of my life: My father was a US Navy pilot Pearl Harbor survivor. I was born in Honolulu in 1947 and I was a Navy brat until I was 11. And I had started playing violin when I was five so I played with the kiddy symphony in Honolulu, I played with the kiddy symphony in Garden Grove, Orange County, California, Pensacola Youth Symphony, blah-blah-blah. My dad retired and bought a farm in the middle of South Mississippi in the middle of nowhere. There was no youth symphony to play with. So I started playing tuba in the marching band and then trombone and then trumpet and then I started playing saxophone with local rock & roll bands when I was 14. That was when my professional career started. But there was no jazz program in the school. I went to school, it went from one to twelve. And they had a marching band that was grade four through twelve. So the music was not very difficult. And they didn't have a jazz program. So when I was 15 I wrote my own arrangements, put my own eight piece jazz band together, and we went to the state stage band festival and won third place and I got a scholarship to the Stan Kenton stage band camp at Indiana University, summer of '63, and I got to study arranging with Herb Pomeroy.

MR: Wow.

TM: So by the time I got to North Texas, that was my third year of college, I had already written extensive big band arrangements for the college band at University of Southern Mississippi. We went to the Mobile Jazz Festival in the spring of '67 and I met Lou Marini there. And I heard Lou Marini's charts and I heard him solo. Lou heard my charts and heard me solo. And he says, "Man you should really transfer to North Texas." So I

the Jimmy Dorsey band. I was the Tommy Dorsey, you know it was mostly the Dorsey brothers' library in the book. And so I saved up enough money to pay my tuition and first month's rent.

MR: There's an anecdote in your bio, or this was an interview you did with somebody, I'm going to read it for a moment: "My first big time gig was playing lead trumpet with Brenda Lee at a club in Jackson, Mississippi. The gig was six nights a week. I always passed out after playing a big, long high C in the middle of the show. I had to hitchhike back and forth to Jackson every night. I was going to class every day in the morning. So every night from two to six AM I was waiting on the side of the road for a ride. The gig paid 16 dollars per night and I spent this time evaluating the music business."

TM: Yes. My father told me if you're going to hitchhike wear a suit. So I had to wear a suit to the gig anyway so — but nobody picked me up until the sun came out.

MR: Wow. I mean that's paying some dues. And I wonder, this is — I wasn't going to go here yet but the current music student that now, at the age you were then, how do they pay dues?

TM: Well the whole music scene, the professional music scene, has drastically changed in New York and LA. I can tell you more about New York. When I got to New York in 1970, January 1970, every TV show had a big band. All three networks had over a hundred musicians on staff getting a weekly check. That doesn't exist anymore. And I have to say that the Saturday Night Live band that we started in 1975 was the first non-big band network TV show. And from then on every new network TV show followed our cue — instead of a big band it was a rhythm & blues band with four or five horns, like we had. We had the band with Lou Marini, Alan Rubin, Howard Johnson, Paul Shaffer — we kind of started a trend. And I guess it was the end of the big band era for the TV shows.

MR: When you were writing for them and for bands with horns, a lot of times like let's say you had trumpet, tenor and trombone. What — is your voicing you'd think, well obviously the trumpet's going to be on the top and the tenor's going to go in the middle and the trombone's on the bottom. Is that true?

TM: Yes.

MR: Or do you mess with that?

TM: Well the mess — no I basically followed the cue of standard rhythm & blues voicings. If you have an F7 chord you have the trumpet on the F at the top, a sixth below you have the tenor on the A, and you have the trombone on the E flat below that. And that's the standard voicing. And when you have a small horn section the best voicing is unison. And when I say unison it's really the trumpet and then the tenor and the trombone one

MR: I get you.

TM: And if you have a baritone sax he's another octave down there. And in the case of that F7 chord you know the baritone sax has a low F.

MR: Right okay.

TM: And the trumpet could have — depending on the, you know whether you want the horns to stick out or not — the trumpet could have the C instead of the F, especially if you have a baritone sax covering the F on the bottom.

MR: I see.

TM: So it could be from the top down C-A-E flat, and then F down on the bottom.

MR: How do you learn that?

TM: I listen carefully to Memphis rhythm & blues: Otis Redding —

MR: The Memphis horns?

TM: The Memphis horns, yes. All the artists that were produced at Stax records.

MR: Did you used to sit by a record player with 45s etcetera, and what was the first thing you would do, okay I want to learn this song or I need to learn this song. You put down the needle. What's the first thing that you find to help?

TM: Chords. Chord progression.

MR: And do you find — did you have a keyboard there or did you just hear it?

TM: Well when I first started I used a keyboard. I was sort of picking out the notes trying to figure out what's what. But for the last 30, 40 years I don't need the keyboard anymore. There's only so many chords. There's only so many voicings. I've already got them in my brain and I hate to brag and say I have perfect pitch but I can listen to a symphony orchestra and I can write in the second clarinet part.

MR: Wow.

TM: And my recent project is that I arranged a pop symphony act for myself. It's a symphony orchestra with a rhythm section. And the concept is orchestral pop hits of the twentieth century. Stuff like "MacArthur Park," "Unforgettable," "Georgia On My Mind," "Kashmir," "Bet You By Golly Wow," you know, "Philadelphia Sound." And the average listener doesn't realize, they just hear their song and they like it or don't like it, but the average person doesn't really know whether their hit song that they like was recorded with an orchestra or not. But I do, and I try to put this together, and I've done four concerts so far. The most successful one I think was a fundraiser at the University of North Texas at the big Murchison Hall. A big fundraiser. And so the after party, there's this slightly older patron lady that comes up to me and says she'd enjoyed the music. And I said, "Thank you, did you recognize any of the songs I played?" She said, "I knew the words to every song you played." I just basically played the melody on these male vocals.

TM: But that's the audience I'm trying to reach because people are not going out to the symphony to hear the Bach, Beethoven, Mozart, Brahms, Debussy, all that stuff. I love all that music. You know I play symphony gigs too but not as much as jazz and pop gigs. But yeah, so they have to do pop music in order to keep themselves financially sound.

MR: Right. One more question about the early time. I'm wondering, as you learned these songs to play in an R & B band etcetera, was there a moment where you realized oh, this is another 12-bar blues?

TM: Well a lot of the pop music is 12-bar blues, especially at the beginning of what they call rock & roll.

MR: Yeah.

TM: And it goes on today. I think rock & roll was an outgrowth of blues music. And I think blues music probably originated in the Delta in Mississippi. But as things progressed, as the music went to Detroit and went to Memphis, they started changing the rhythms, you know the rock & roll rhythms somehow came into the picture.

MR: I see that you even did Ringling Brothers circus gigs, is that true?

TM: Yes. Yes. We did, in Fort Worth we did ten shows in twenty — no twenty shows in ten days. Yes. And it was non-stop. I mean it really took a lot of chops to play that gig. There was another guy sitting next to me that — when I was tired he would take over. But it was a lot of playing. And once again, and you had to play as fast as you could and then the guy would just cut you off anywhere, you know, as soon as the elephant got up on his hind legs the song was over and you went on to something else. But it was non-stop until you had a little ten minute break in the middle. It was a ridiculous job. But you learn, you know you have to play every style of music because you never know what you're going to get called for.

MR: Doesn't it go along with having the attitude like I don't have to love this music, I just have to play it correctly?

TM: Well that's true, that is true. I don't have to love the artist that I'm performing for either. But I have to play the music accurately.

MR: Did you ever get in a situation in a studio with horns where they didn't have parts for you?

TM: Oh I've done that many times. Yes.

MR: And how does that work?

TM: You play the parts by ear. Yes. Okay Paul McCartney, "Egypt Station" 2018. I was an honorary member of the Muscle Shoals Horns. I'd done a couple of gigs with the Muscle Shoals Horns in Muscle Shoals. The fortieth anniversary of the "Last Waltz" movie, a movie that I was in, we did it in Muscle Shoals with the Muscle Shoals Horns. And I

section. So Charles Rose, the head of the section, he got called to do Paul McCartney in New York, do his album. And he didn't know what they were going to play. They didn't send him any music in advance, any charts, anything. They flew us out there and put us up at a hotel and said, "We'll pick you up at 11:00." We didn't know where the session was. So we show up, they picked us up at 11 and we go to Henson's Studios, it used to be A & M Studios, it used to be Charlie Chaplin's studios. And Paul comes out and starts playing a song, starts playing the track, and he comes out into the studio where the horns are set up and starts playing a line on the guitar. "I want the horns to play this line." So we listened carefully and we copped a line and played it. He says, "That's it." So we dropped it into the recording four or five times and then we went on to the next song. And the second song he says, "Turn up this keyboard part." He turns up the keyboard part. The keyboard is playing a line. So, "I want you guys to play that line." So we listened by ear, copped that line, and we dropped it into the song four or five times. Song number 3 — Paul comes out with his guitar, while they're playing the track he plays this line on the guitar. We listened carefully, copped the line, he says, "That's it." Okay so we got the line. Now he says, "The notes are right but it sounds too low." Baritone sax, change to something. So the baritone sax player picks up — puts down his baritone and picks up an alto sax and we played it again. And then he says, "Well the notes are right but it still sounds too low. Somebody do something." So I put down the tenor sax and picked up the piccolo. "That's it!" So we dropped it into the song. We did six songs in six hours like that, including lunch, Paul bought us lunch. And by the way he was the nicest guy. It wasn't like he was up here and I was down here, he just — it was just like you and I talking. It was just a very wonderful person besides being, you know, as great as he is in music. Obviously the leader of The Beatles.

MR: And you have to have the ear and the patience, lack of attitude, to be successful at that.

TM: Absolutely. You have to leave your ego at the door. If you go in to do a session for somebody it's not about you, it's about the artist. It's about the arranger. It's about the producer. It's about the engineer. It's about getting your sound on the microphone properly, playing the right volume, setting up in the right location.

MR: I'm thinking that your degree in psychology may even be a little more valuable than a degree in music.

TM: Well when you're dealing with musicians a degree in psychology certainly helps.

MR: Speaking of that, have you been in sessions where there was an ad person, you know a commercial, and the ad person and the producer may be one and the same, that made tempers flare somewhat?

TM: There's always someone that can cause anxiety, yes. And you never know what's going

have a defense mechanism against anything that would ordinarily make you angry. You can't — you don't have time in a session to get angry. Oh here's a story you might enjoy. Gladys Knight and the Pips Christmas album. A 48-piece orchestra in the studio, and so we spent at least the first two hours just rehearsing and getting the mix correct, getting the sounds and everything correct. So then we started in on the songs and we had all the songs done except one. There were three songs we were recording. Okay? So now we have one more song to do and we have about 15 minutes left on the session. And okay, "Ave Maria." So the conductor counts off and we start in to the song and in the booth they go, "Cut it off, cut it off." And they called the conductor back in to the — conductor/arranger — they called him back into the control room and you see there's some commotion going on in there. Well it turns out there are two different songs called "Ave Maria."

MR: No.

TM: And so he arranged the wrong "Ave Maria." Okay? So now there's a lot of commotion in there. So they decide to record this version of "Ave Maria." And Gladys Knight is in there so they figure out what key she should do it in so now there's five minutes left in the session. There's time for one take. And the conductor walks in and he says, "'Ave Maria' down a fourth. One-two-three-four." And that's the one that's on the record. Everybody transposed it instantaneously.

MR: Wow. I'm speechless. You know for — I play alto so I'm pretty good at you know, up a minor third from concert, etcetera, or you know tenor down, but that's really something. It reminds me of Frank Wess who would play tenor parts on his alto with Basie 'cause he was too lazy to pick up the other horn or whatever, and he just did that.

TM: Well I can do that, I can read an alto part on tenor and vice versa, tenor part on alto. I can read a trumpet part on the trombone. I can read a baritone part — I can do that too. Being an arranger you know I can read any horn part on any other, yeah, just because I've been doing it so long.

MR: What's your sweet spot for, let's say you're able to put a horn section together, there's a modest budget — what's the sweet spot for you as far as number of horns?

TM: It depends on the style of music. A typical rock & roll session is trumpet, tenor, trombone, baritone. Now Tower of Power had two trumpets, two tenors, and baritone. And, but that four-piece thing for rhythm & blues and rock & roll is pretty much standard.

MR: There's a wide range —

TM: I do sessions at my house where a client says — you know they send me the track and the vocal and they say, "We need horns on this." So I'll arrange the horns and I'll put the

horns on, one at a time, at my house. Email it back to them. It's the new way of doing things.

MR: What do you get — do you get a recording and a lead sheet or what?

TM: Sometimes I do it by ear, sometimes I write out the parts. It just depends on the complexity. But once again unison is always the strongest horn voicing when you have a small horn section. Jerry Hey is one of my horn arranging heroes — Michael Jackson, Earth, Wind & Fire, Brothers Johnson, Quincy Jones, Al Jarreau — particularly Al Jarreau "High Crime," that album. And once again it's that horn unison with the, you know the tenor and the trombone an octave below the trumpets. And sometimes he's got the trumpets up another octave, doubled up an octave. Sometimes he has three upper horn octaves going on. Yeah.

MR: Okay so it makes me think of a tune. See if you can name this tune, speaking of unison horns (scats).

TM: That was the best big band session I ever played on. "Late in the Evening" by Paul Simon from the movie — what was the name of the movie, it's a soundtrack album. I did not get credit on the album, but it was the best big band I ever played with in New York. We played — it was arranged by Dave Grusin. "One Trick Pony" is the name of the movie.

MR: That's right.

TM: "Late in the Evening" is the name of the song. Okay. Trumpets: Jon Faddis, Lew Soloff, Al Rubin, Randy Brecker. Saxes: George Young, Lou Marini, Michael Brecker, Eddie Daniels, Ronnie Cuber baritone sax. Rhythm section: Steve Gadd, Tony Levin on bass, Richard Tee on piano, Hugh McCracken on guitar. We did sixteen takes in a three hour session. That's all we had is one chart to do.

MR: I bet you guys played it right the first time though.

TM: Yes. We did — all sixteen were perfect takes.

MR: I love that. That's like, "That was perfect, let's do it again."

TM: And that was the best band I ever played in, best big band that I ever played in. Trombones: well myself and Jim Pugh, Dave Taylor, Barry Rogers, the guys that played in the group Dreams with the Brecker brothers. He was the first Latin trombone player. He was the first salsa trombone player. Jewish kid from the Bronx, grew up in a Puerto Rican neighborhood. Before Barry Rogers, they only had saxophones and trumpets in salsa music and suddenly Barry came on the scene and bang, it was all over. Now every salsa band has a trombone. And I played on all the salsa recordings in New York too. Fania Records, 1974, '75, '76. Willie Colon, Hector Lavoe, Ruben Blades, Johnny Pacheco, Mongo Santamaria, the Lebron brothers. All those guys. Cheo Feliciano.

MR: With that Paul Simon tune, who would have been responsible for assembling that all-star

TM: To be honest with you I can't remember who the contractor was.

MR: Okay. But Paul Simon trusted some contractor and was he the one that caused sixteen takes?

TM: Yes. He would — well he didn't like this and he didn't like that. He was a very kind of picky guy. I'm not saying that he doesn't have the right to be picky, it's his music. It's his. So once again, it's not for me to criticize him. It's for me to make him happy regardless of whether I think it sounds perfect or not. I'm not the producer, I'm not the artist, I'm not the arranger, I'm not the engineer. Yeah. So you just have to keep that attitude. And I could have played it seventeen times. I just liked playing with that band. If that's the only chart we had, okay fine. Bang. Let's do another take.

MR: Was everybody playing at the same time?

TM: Yes. Yes. A lot of — well I'll say most studio recordings, you know, they record the rhythm section first and then they record the horns, and then they record the strings, you know separately, and you know it's for many reasons, especially including leakage. But you know you concentrate on the rhythm, you get that right, concentrate on the horns, get that right, concentrate on the strings, get that right. And you know vocals are always separate too. Sometimes they put the vocal on first because you need to see how the parts interact with the vocal, but sometimes they — once the arrangement is laid out sometimes they do that later. Or a lot of times they'll put down a scratch vocal to work with and then they'll do a final vocal later where they'll get real picky and take their time with it.

MR: Did you know Joe Wilder?

TM: Of course. Oh yeah. What a phenomenal musician and a nice guy.

MR: Indeed. He told me that some — he didn't mention names — but he said when the studio scene was so happening that guys would get a little over-zealous and take — if they had a ten to one and then they would book a one to four, knowing that either they were going to have to get out of something early or arrive late.

TM: Well we did that frequently during the 70s and 80s. You know I basically played Saturday Night Live on the weekend and I did recording sessions all during the week. And I was in a group of people who were in demand. So people like Alan Rubin, Marvin Stamm, Lou Marini, George Young, the Brecker brothers — we would book stuff — we'd book a jingle from one to two and another jingle two to three. And we would usually get it done early because we knew we had another session. And that's why they booked us, they knew that we weren't going to waste their time. But sometimes for whatever reason, you know the rhythm would go overtime and then we would go in late and so we'd show up — but we showed up — if we showed up ten minutes late for the

in walking distance. So if we showed up ten minutes late we all showed up together and we got the job done. So even though that happened occasionally — I got into the business in New York — I met Bill Watrous early on and he would send me in to sub for him, to cover. I'd show up and I'd say, "Bill Watrous will be here in ten minutes," and I'd play until he got there. And that's the way I established myself in the business. Yeah. Bill Watrous and I became friends. I was playing trombone with a group called Eclipse. It was an up-and-coming rock band with original music. And I was the trombone player and Bill wanted to be in the band. He wanted to get into the rock & roll scene you know, as opposed to the jazz scene. So I switched over to electric bass and he became the trombone player in the group. Then I started playing with a group called Ten Wheel Drive. Three trumpets, trombone, and bari sax. I was the trombone player. Bill's good friend Danny Styles was the lead trumpet player in the band. So Bill wanted to be in the band so I switched over to trumpet and he became the trombone player. So you help friends out in the business and it always pays off one way or the other. And Bill got me in the business. Bill moved to L.A. in 1975 but six, seven years later I remember getting a call from a guy and I said — a guy I didn't know — I said, "Where did you get my name?" "Bill Watrous recommended you." Six, seven years ago. So it just pays off to be nice to everybody, whatever that means.

MR: You just said something that I wanted to follow up on. The group of people that I graduated with, we all had aspirations to maybe get in a big band, oh my God if we could get in Buddy Rich's big band. Most of them took the fall-back position and became public school teachers, which is an honorable, you know, position. But for those of you in that group that had aspirations to be jazz musicians, to have a band, to record for Blue Note, like your musical heroes did, but now you're playing two, three, four sessions a day and I wonder if that ever got to be like, wow what happened? This is not what I anticipated.

TM: Well you make plans in your life based on what's going on around you at the time. But everything changes and you have to be willing to change with the style of music. I know when I first got to New York, 1970, the studio recording scene was in a transition from big band and jazz to rock & roll. And there were a lot of guys like bass players, drummers — oh this rock & roll thing's never going to catch on, I don't want to play that junk. You know they used a different word. And so, and those guys were out of the business overnight. And there were other guys, like let's say upright jazz bass player, listened to the rock & roll stuff and says, "I can do that. I can play electric bass. I can play that rock & roll stuff." And these people continued to be busy players — drummers, bass players, guitar players, you know. So you have to roll with the punches. You have to

to be the same twelve notes. But you have to be able to play jazz, you have to play Latin, you have to play classical, you have to play whatever style of music, you just have to play it. There's Hasidic pop recordings too, in Brooklyn. Mordechai Ben David, Avraham Fried, all those guys, Yeedle, all of them. They dress up like the Blues Brothers too.

MR: Yes I noticed that. I just read, I thought it was pretty hip that, the way that thing came together and Dan Akroyd, your first assignment, if this is true, said, "Write an arrangement for some horn parts for Rocket 88."

TM: Well here's the story: I was the arranger for Saturday Night Live from 1975 to 1985. And spring of 1978 the music director asked me to meet with John and Danny in John's office at 2:00 on Monday afternoon. And it was just the three of us. And they were talking about, they were developing these characters, these guys that wore sunglasses day and night, and they were n'er do well blues musicians in Chicago. So I wrote an arrangement of "Rocket 88" by James Cotton. We did it for Lorne Michaels, producer, after I rehearsed the Saturday Night Live band on my chart. Turned us down. Didn't make the show. Week number two, John and Danny are still hot on this idea of the Blues Brothers. So I wrote an arrangement of the song called "Hey Bartender." I rehearsed the band, we did it for Lorne Michaels, the producer, Lorne says, "Frankly I don't see anything funny about the Blues Brothers." Week number two, shot us down. So the next week John and Danny gave up on the Blues Brothers. If Lorne doesn't like it, if we're not getting on the show we're wasting our time. Couldn't argue. So the third week Lorne comes out of read-through 3:15 on a Wednesday afternoon and he says, "The show's three minutes short what are we going to do?" He used the H word in there somewhere. And John and Danny jumped on him and said, "Lorne, the Blues Brothers." So Lorne said, "We have nothing worthwhile to put in those three minutes, you guys might as well make fools of yourselves." He put us on the show. And he put us at the end of the show so that in case the show ran long, you know he could cut us. But the show did not run long, we got on the show and I suppose the rest is history in a certain sense of the word.

MR: Did you think, in the initial stages, that it was supposed to be funny? Was that the intention?

TM: I was not in charge of what they did as characters on stage. I was only asked to write music arrangements and I tried to make sure that the band played the music, you know played those correctly, you know in the right style and the right feel. And it wasn't up to me whether they were funny or not.

MR: Yeah. It wasn't Spike Jones funny. It was, if it was going to be funny it was going to be those two guys.

TM: Exactly. They — yeah. We just backed up these guys, and that was — my whole career at Saturday Night Live for ten years I was arranger for ten — I was also the music director from '81 to '85. You know Eddie Murphy, Joe Piscopo, Martin Short, Billy Crystal era. I wrote the music to "Hot Tub." I didn't write the lyrics but I wrote "Hot Tub" and I produced the pre-record for that scene.

MR: Were you writing with score paper and pencil during this time?

TM: I did. I started out with score paper and I had a copyist. I'd take the stuff at like eleven or twelve at night, take it to the copyist up on the Upper West Side and he would show up in the morning at the show with the parts copies out professionally. Now, ever since computer notation software has come out I do it all in there and it speeds up the process. You know cutting and pasting, it just is so much faster. And I don't use the copyist anymore, I can lay out the parts quite rapidly and print them out, or email them out, and that's the way I do it. I use a software called Overture. Most people use Sibelius or Finale. But I helped Overture, I was a beta tester for Overture when they were developing the software and I was using it on the TV shows, so I would find mistakes in the software, send it to the company, they would send me a beta version, and ten or twelve beta versions later they would release a new version to the general public for sale. So I got a very inside view on how this stuff works.

MR: That's cool because I know Finale has some things that are quite annoying but to be in on the development of it you're not going to get annoyances when you get the final product.

TM: Well as far as I know, Finale is more the standard for the publishing business. And although Sibelius has some advantages too, and I have both of those softwares, but there's always a deadline when I do an arrangement so I just always go back to Overture because I'm lightening fast on that. One night — I was arranger for the David Letterman show for 22 years. One night, we did — our basic schedule was we did the show from 4:30 to 5:30 PM and then it was broadcast at 11:30. Anyway, one night — the show's over around 5:30, 5:35. I go upstairs and I'm changing clothes and I'm almost out of the building and, "Can you meet with Paul in Paul's dressing room?" Okay so Paul has two CDs in his hand. He says, "Renee Fleming's going to do the Top 10 tomorrow. We need thirteen opera excerpts by eleven in the morning. And here's the thirteen opera excerpts. He gives me a CD. And the other CD, this is Renee Fleming's most recent recording album product, figure out what key she should sing them in."

MR: Wow.

TM: You're supposed to have a rehearsal with the piano and the vocalist before you do this. Anyway so that part was left out. And then Paul looks at me with a panic look on his face and he says, "Bones, how are we going to pull this off?" I said, "I'll play flute, Aaron

play the string parts on the string synthesizer. There's your opera." And we've all heard opera. We know, we can —." So I stayed up all night, did all the stuff, and all night while I was staying up I was thinking to myself Renee Fleming has got to be a real diva. She's going to be difficult. It turns out to be exactly the opposite. She had a great sense of humor, very easy to work with, just nicest person ever. And I had one of the songs in the wrong key. I brought my laptop with me, quickly transposed all the parts and printed it out in Paul's office next door. Five minutes later there it is. And it's on YouTube. Renee Fleming, David Letterman, Top 10.

MR: I'll check it out.

TM: Yeah. They changed all the — you know the writers changed all the original lyrics to funny lyrics. And she was delightful. So you never know. I was an arranger for a show called, a TV special called "The Fortieth Anniversary of Atlantic Records." It was at the Garden, Madison Square Garden. Giant audience. And it was a 14-1/2 hour concert. It started at 10 in the morning and went 'til 2:30 in the morning. The closing act was Led Zeppelin, who had not performed for six years. Anyway, everybody in the history of Atlantic Records was there. I had done thirty arrangements before the show, and so we got there and we played with the first act at 10:00, went back to the dressing room and then Ahmet Ertegun comes in the dressing room and he says, "No concert of Atlantic Records would be complete without Bobby Darin being represented." So I said, "Mack the Knife?" Tim from the Manhattan Transfer is sitting next to me and he says, "I know the song." So I had brought score paper with me. This was before computers. I started filling out the score, I started writing the chart. And they called my copyist to come in and copy the part. And we walked on stage and sight read the song and he sang the song just bang, just like that. I walked down the hall and I ran into Trevor Rabin. "You guys on the show?" "Yeah." "What song you doing?" "Owner of the Lonely Heart." I said, "Wouldn't it be great if you had real horns playing the horn licks in the middle of the song?" He said, "Yeah can we do that?" You know I knew the parts. You know I had played and recorded with James Brown so I mean those were lifted right out of one of his records. So I wrote out the parts and the horn section went on and sight read them on live TV. The horn section was Alan Rubin, Lou Marini, Tom Scott, and myself. So boom. So I wrote two arrangements after the show started. Another time, the Letterman show, they sent a camera down to 48th Street and they go in with a remote camera — they go into Sam Ash music — here's a kid with a trumpet case over his shoulder in the store. And they said, "You want to sit in with the Letterman band?" And the kid looks at the camera and says, "When?" They said, "Right now." The kid ran away. He ran out of the store onto the street. Then they found another kid in there with a tenor sax over his shoulder.

ran out in the street. So now there's a girl behind the counter. "Do you play an instrument?" "Yes." "What do you play?" "Alto sax." "You want to sit in with the Letterman — do you have your horn with you?" "Yeah it's right here." "You want to sit in with the Letterman band?" "When?" "Right now." "Sure." So the camera's following her up Broadway to 52nd Street to the studio and she comes up on the stage and Paul says, "What songs do you know?" She says, "Well I don't know any songs by ear but if you can write them out for me I can play them." So, "Okay well 'Isn't She Lovely,' Tom what key should she play it in?" Bang, write her a part. Bang, bang, I wrote her out a part, handed it to her. Just as soon as I handed it to her Paul counts off the song. And we did the whole show like that. What song — the rhythm section in the band knew everything so we just basically — you know I just wrote out songs for her that they knew and that was the whole show.

MR: Yeah I've often wondered about that, you have everyone from Sonny & Cher to Renee Fleming on the show and there's got to be some very hip musicians who not only can play anything but can hear anything and play in the correct style and so forth.

TM: Yes, yes. Well we had a remarkable rhythm section on that show, you know Anton Fig on drums, Will Lee on bass, and the guys had been everywhere, played everything. And a lot of times artists would come on, "Well hey, I played on the original record, yeah I know the part." So but yeah, that's one of the necessary skills for a TV musician because you never know who they're going to put on there. You know? Snoop — I wrote charts, horn charts for Snoop Dogg one time. We did that song called "Get the Funk Out of My Face" written by Quincy Jones. And Quincy Jones is sitting in the chair next to Dave. That was a thrill for me. James Brown sat in with the band for a whole show one night. Jimmy Smith, the famous organ player, sat in with us the whole — we did "Who's Afraid of Virginia Woolf" and I got to write out some parts. We got to back up so many cool people, oh my God.

MR: What happens to all this music that you've written?

TM: A lot of it, the stuff is still in my computer. They threw up giant piles of music at the Letterman Show when the show ended. I grabbed up a few but —

MR: How do you charge for your arranging?

TM: Oh well there's a formula — the union book has a way — it's by the measure or the score page or something. There's a way of breaking it down. So it's all mathematical.

MR: Is it further broken down like there's twelve voices here as opposed to four, etcetera?

TM: Well it depends on the number of staves on the score and the number of bars, or number of score pages or something like that. I just worked out a deal with Shaffer where it was, everything was the same price and then I just used the same formula. It was by the bar is

what I do, so I just multiply it bar the bar formula and that was how I billed Shaffer on the Letterman Show.

MR: "And by the way I stayed up all night doing this one so do I get a tip?"

TM: Not one penny extra. No.

MR: Okay.

TM: But I got a substantial check for doing Renee Fleming. And I got a substantial check for doing the Atlantic Records Fortieth because not only did they do the 14-1/2 hour live cable show but CBS did a two hour special that they edited out of there so I got two sizable checks.

MR: Nice and do you get some sizable checks that show up in your mailbox that you have to figure out where they came from?

TM: Well you pick them up at the union so you know exactly where they came from. Yeah. Well while I was with the Letterman Show the Dean of Music at North Texas State came up to New York and took me out to lunch. And they needed somebody to be the director of the 1:00 Lab Band. You know so I asked him how much it paid and he told me how much it paid and I was making more than three times that much at the Letterman Show. So because I was playing seven instruments on a daily basis and arranging, so you know I had to turn it down. But yeah, on the bandstand I had baritone sax, bass trombone, trombone, trumpet, flugelhorn, piccolo trumpet, tenor sax, alto sax, flute, piccolo and alto flute on the bandstand every day. So you know you get paid a little extra when you play more than one instrument.

MR: You need a roadie. Have you ever turned down any work either because financially it didn't work for you or it just was out of your realm of feeling you could do a good job with it?

TM: I never turned down any for the last reason. I never turned down anything for that reason. If somebody wanted me to go out of town and didn't offer me enough money I would turn it down.

MR: Okay.

TM: Yeah.

MR: There's a quote from you, I'm looking at my wall, it says, "If you're called to do a job you don't really want to do ask for more money. You can market yourself as either a Pinto or a Mercedes."

TM: Well that's true. Yeah. If it's a job you really, really don't want to do just ask for more money and that way you're not really turning it down. You're not technically turning it down. Then it reverses the psychology. Now they're the one that's turning you down, the employer.

TM: It turns it completely around.

MR: Talk about, let's talk about Gil Evans a little more. I was having a — reading something and trying to write something about the major innovators in jazz history and the fact that the majority of them are African-American. So then I went like well who's the first white musician that seemed to make a significant contribution to changing jazz. And I thought of Gil Evans, I thought of Bix, but I thought of Gil Evans as a writer. Would you agree with that?

TM: I would totally agree with that, yes. We're talking about "Porgy & Bess," "Miles Ahead," "Sketches in Spain" particularly. "Sketches in Spain," Gil Evans arranging for Miles Davis. Now I did the 1983 "Miles and Gil Tour Japan." And I also played on the last recording of Miles Davis and Quincy Jones in Montreux, Switzerland, 1991. Miles passed away about three weeks later. But you know Miles was certainly a big influence. And Gil Evans was my musical father for his last fifteen years. We played, among other things we played every Monday night at Sweet Basil's for eight years and cranked out two or three albums that that sold very well in Japan. Gil had a different way of voicing things. You know like jazz musicians and big band musicians have a standard way of voicing things, where you have a, if you have a three note chord — I mean a four note chord you leave out the root or the fifth in the upper voicings. Gil Evans had a different way of voicing things. He always had all three of the — you know the one, three, and five of the chord in the upper harmony, plus another note that was rarely the seventh. He would put an extra note in there. This is — in his own words, he said, "It's like a barber shop quartet with one extra note." And the extra note was always a half step away from one of the primary notes of the triad. Example: okay a major chord, a major triad, C, G and E, he'd throw an A flat in there. In other words he'd have a plus five and a regular five at the same time next to each other.

MR: Right in the same octave?

TM: Right. Right next to each other. Yeah. C-A flat-G-E. Like that. And a minor chord, he would have, he'd frequently have, one of his — let's say okay A [meant E] minor: G-E-B-B flat. In other words you had a plus eleven right next to the fifth. That was a typical voicing of Gil Evans. And if you listen carefully to those charts you'll hear those voicings in there.

MR: Did the chord symbols for the keyboard and/or guitar indicate those voicings?

TM: Yes. Yes.

MR: So they knew what was going on.

TM: Yeah. His chord symbols were very exacting in his charts. And I wrote an album, shortly after Gil died I wrote an album called — a small group album with four horns,

of Gil alive so I wrote a whole bunch of jazz standards with the Gil Evans voicings in them. And it was Jon Faddis, Alex Foster, Bill Evans the tenor player, myself on the trombone, Danny Gottlieb, Mark Egan and Gil Goldstein. That was the band.

MR: It's like you've cloned yourself to be in so many places seemingly in the same time.

TM: Well the more versatile you are the more gigs you're going to get.

MR: Well then you just answered my next question, was that your neighbor's son takes you aside and go, "I'd really like to have some advice, I'd like to do what you did, I'd like to be a full time musician." And they're like 17. Do you have anything to say to them considering how much the business has changed?

TM: Well when I started, I started practicing when I was around 13 I was practicing four, five hours a day, all the way through high school. I was living on a farm in the middle of nowhere in South Mississippi and I didn't want to stay on the farm and milk cows and haul hay, picking corn. Nothing wrong with that, there's nothing wrong with that it just wasn't for me. You know farming is an honorable profession but I practiced because I heard this record by Urbie Green and I wanted to move to New York and be a professional musician so I practiced. My mother would say, "Tommy it's time to go to sleep now, it's time to stop playing." So I might stay up a little later and noodle around on the piano trying to figure out what the notes were on a record, but you know you've got to do the work. You've got to really practice. And also the professional opportunities are not there for a young musician. It's not — New York is not like it was when I moved there in 1970. They don't have all these — the job opportunities are shrinking, it's not getting better for what I do, like in New York, the recording business is almost not there. All the professional musicians I used to do studio work with are doing Broadway shows. That wasn't for me to play exactly the same music eight times a week with no improvisation. That's not why I got into the business. Basically what I do is headline jazz festivals and go out and work with kids and play my own charts.

MR: So that's one thing that you might have turned down for musical reasons, to get on, you know get in "Phantom of the Opera" pit and all your financial worries are taken care of.

TM: I subbed down there a couple of nights actually, playing bass trombone. And the music was wonderful oh my goodness, yes. But you know going back to the question you asked me earlier in the interview about turning down jobs, yeah I never, I had the opportunity to do Broadway shows and I never did because I just knew it wasn't for me. There's nothing wrong with that, all my friends were playing Broadway shows and they're paying their rent and supporting their families, and it's honorable. And some of the new shows are quite interesting. "Ain't Too Proud" about the Temptations. I was on the road with the Temptations in 1969, yeah. It was the Supremes and the Temptations, the original guy.

so there's a lot of — you know there's good stuff going on. So my friend Ross Konikoff played trumpet on "Cats" for twenty years. So you know it's all kinds — all kinds of different music, all kinds of different professional opportunities. Young musicians that come out of college that come to New York and that's what they want to do is play a Broadway show, and a lot of them are woodwind players that learn to play a lot of different instruments because they knew that was a requirement to play on Broadway.

MR: Do you have anything to offer up about Frank Zappa?

TM: Oh Frank Zappa was a unique individual. His viewpoint on the world was different than anybody I ever knew. You know you and I might look out on the street and just — "What's going on, there's cars and —" but Frank would see something and find humor in it. Example: we were on the road with a 10-piece Mothers of Invention, we were — in December 1972 we were in Philadelphia and we were playing at University of Pennsylvania in Philadelphia. There was about eight inches of snow on the ground. We get off the bus and right there by the sidewalk there's a fire hydrant that has little yellow streaks around it. And so during the sound check Frank wrote "Don't Eat the Yellow Snow." He was a piece of work, Frank. One time he had a — when I was playing with him, you know I moved out to L.A. to play with him. One time he had a 48-hour party at his house and you could come and go as you wanted during the 48 hours. And in 1972 this was before videocassette or DVD but you could rent any movie in Hollywood, 8 millimeter, 16 millimeter, 35 millimeter. So he had this giant, big, empty basement and it had purple carpet and orange walls. And he had a projection booth in the corner with a 16 millimeter projector. So he hired — he rented 48 hours worth of movies, "Freaks," "Godzilla," "Chainsaw" you know all the weirdest movies he could find. And he would sit there and drink coffee and make snide comments about the movies. Once again, his viewpoint on all this stuff was unique. And you know he would make you laugh even in the most serious part of a movie. And I came by there with my girlfriend at two in the morning, party's going on, stayed 'til four.

MR: Did he write out all those very intricate melodies?

TM: Everything was written out. He had — everything was written out. I got the job with Frank by playing the tuba over the telephone. He was looking for a tuba player for "The Grand Wazoo" and so I played the tuba over the telephone, went over to his house the next day and he says, he says, "Sal Marquez tells me you play other instruments besides the tuba." And I said, "Yeah." So he said, "Well give me a list." And so I put down bass trombone, trombone, trumpet, flugelhorn, piccolo trumpet, tenor sax, flute and piccolo. And I showed up for rehearsal two weeks later and he had rearranged all his music so I had a part for every instrument. Yeah. Frank was a great influence on my life. And I did

tour. Then he cut down the band to 6 pieces. And he says, "We're only going to have one horn on the next tour" and he says, "it's going to be Bruce Fowler." I said, "Cool." He says, "Bruce tells me you play electric bass." I said, "Yeah." He says, "Well you want to audition?" I said, "Sure." I went over to his house one day and I remember Ralph Humphreys was there — he just passed away last week, sadly — and George Duke was there playing keyboards. So I auditioned on electric bass, thought I sounded pretty good. A couple of weeks go by, nothing. I called up Frank, leave a message on his phone. "Hey Frank it's Tom, let me know what's going on." Another week goes by, nothing. I get a call from Blood, Sweat & Tears in New York, "Chuck Winfield's leaving the band we need a trumpet player. Can you be in New York tomorrow?" I said, "Sure." So I gave away my car, checked all my stuff on the plane, my girlfriend — who later became my wife — stayed for a day or two to pack up stuff and come out later. And Frank called to say I had the job playing bass with him. The next day, after I left, he calls to say I had the job playing with George Duke and Jean Luc Ponty on the tour in '73. Three tours of Europe and a tour of Japan for double the money that Blood, Sweat & Tears was paying. But I was gone. And I recommended Tom Fowler, who was Bruce Fowler's brother (electric bass player). Frank loved him, played with Frank for several years. You know I covered my tracks. That's what — if you turn down a job you always recommend somebody who is competent, and that way — that's the way the business is. That way you save face you know. That's just the way it's done.

MR: This has really been a fascinating conversation, I think we could probably do a part 2 and a part 3.

TM: Yes we could.

MR: Yeah. Well maybe we should but I want to close with a question about — I read about the plastic military figures and "1812 Overture." Is that ringing a bell?

TM: Well I know the "1812 Overture."

MR: Yes well it says in your own hand, or in an interview, that when you were a little kid your parents bought your first record player.

TM: Yes, yes. I was living in Hawaii at the time, I was four or five years old and I heard all this music and yeah, we used to play war. My dad was a military officer. We used to play war. My brother and I used to play war and my brother got a violin and, you know, because of listening to that music, you know the violin [scats] I can still remember all that music, and so my brother got a violin and the only reason I wanted a violin is because, hey, my brother's got one I want one too. You know that's what childhood — so I got my own violin. I guess he got one when he was six — he was two years older than me. So by the time he was seven I was five, and my parents bought me a violin and I still

have it. It's a 1/16. It almost looks like a toy violin or something. I'm going to get it re-strung and fixed up, put it on the wall.

MR: Nice, well it said something about toy soldiers — you'd play war with the toy soldiers.

TM: Yes. It had those little miniature — I'm trying to — was it a Mattel? I'm trying to remember, little toy soldiers and we used play with, my brother and I used to play with them on the floor.

MR: Yeah. Me too.

TM: While we were playing that music. Yeah. And it was indeed about war. That music was about war.

MR: Indeed. [scats]

TM: Yeah. Like the trumpet stuff and lots of minor key stuff. And you know some orchestras even today if they do an outdoor concert they'll bring the cannons, yeah, for the finale part.

MR: I hope those guys get hazardous duty pay. Oh my. Well thank you very much for this enlightening hour, and I'll let you get back to your whatever arranging thing is. By the way, when you have an arrangement assignment, before you sit down, does something start to rattle around in your head even before like you're sitting with your computer or something?

TM: Oh of course. If I have a clue as to what I'm going to do. I usually listen to the music and then all kinds of ideas come into my mind and when I get in front of the computer I just filter through those ideas. But a lot of stuff I do is for rock stuff with vocals on them so basically you either fill in the slots — okay slots what does he mean by that? The — like the singer sings a passage and there's a little pause before they sing another lyric so you basically put a little lick in there and that's usually where the unison comes in. And there are other parts of the song where you might have a subtle chord backing them up, you know like whole notes, while they're actually singing on top of you. But the idea is you don't conflict with the vocal because the vocal is the most important thing you know. If I'm just putting horn parts on I just make sure that they have — they occur in their own space and don't interfere with the vocal. Because I'm just the frosting on the cake. That's all.

MR: Okay. I've sometimes told students if they want to get fired from a band — they're a horn player and they want to get fired — just start playing when the singer is singing.

TM: Oh easily. Yeah. Or play too loud. Bang. Next? Who is the next trombone player. Yeah.

MR: Well thank you for the frosting on the cake, Tom.

TM: It's my pleasure to talk with you. Call me up anytime. We'll do it again, we can talk for days.

TM: My pleasure.